

FOR A LONG TIME I THOUGHT BEING A GOOD WRITER MEANT LEARNING HOW
NOT TO BE WRONG

A Window

TS 98 · NANFITO · ASSESSMENT #6: REFLECTION

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For a long time, I thought being a good writer meant learning how not to be wrong. I felt that especially in Business Communications. I could sit in front of an assignment checking the format, the wording, the punctuation, the tone, then check it all again, and somehow still expect to find a red mark waiting for me. There was always another rule hiding somewhere. Eventually, I stopped thinking about what I wanted to say and started thinking almost entirely about what I might have done incorrectly. That is a strange place to write from because your own voice gets quieter while you are busy trying to protect yourself from mistakes. This class felt almost like opening a window after being in that room too long. The rules did not disappear, but suddenly they were supporting my writing instead of standing in front of it.

I discovered that I love research because I rarely research anything without becoming emotionally involved in what I find. My subjects have been all over the place: the psychology of human emotion, crypto chains, scholarship essays, my immune

deficiency, mental health resources for my son, poetry, and the occasional piece of strange or witty prose that appears because apparently my brain does not believe in staying inside one category. Some of that research begins with curiosity, but some of it begins because something matters enough that I need to understand it. **When I researched my immune deficiency, I was not studying an interesting medical condition from a comfortable distance.** I was trying to put language around something that has existed inside my own life. When I searched for mental health support for my son, the words on the screen carried a completely different weight because the outcome mattered to someone I love. Research can look cold from the outside, all sources and facts and evidence, but I have learned that for me it is often deeply emotional work. I gather facts because sometimes understanding something is the only way I know how to begin fighting for it.

My thoughts do not usually arrive neatly organized. They come as fragments. A sentence while I am doing something else. A question that refuses to leave. A connection between two ideas that seemed unrelated until suddenly they are not. I might read something and think I have forgotten it, only to have it return three days later and attach itself perfectly to another thought. This class helped me stop seeing that process as a defect in the way I write. The college essays gave me room to follow those connections, research them, challenge them, and eventually build something coherent from what initially looked scattered. That process feels much more natural to me than beginning with a perfectly formed answer. I do not want research to tell me what to think.

I want it to give me enough information that I can wrestle with the question until I know what I believe.

Maybe that is why this class has meant more to me than simply becoming better at sentence structure. I learned that emotion and intelligence do not cancel each other out. I can care deeply about something and still question it. I can write from personal experience without abandoning research, and I can use structure without sanding every rough edge off my voice. That matters to me as I move further into graphic and web design because design is another language built from choices. A blank space can create tension. A photograph can hold grief. Typography can whisper, shout, or disappear into the background, just as a sentence can. I want to share what I have learned through the things I create, through the documents I use to advocate for people I love, and through conversations with people who may also believe they are somehow “wrong” at writing. I think the most important thing this class gave me was permission to trust that there is value in the way my mind works.

My voice was not missing. I had just spent so much time correcting it that I had forgotten what it sounded like.

